

Deceptive techniques can be broadly classified into two types: those that try to fool the search engines, and those that try to fool human searchers. For example, the title of a page may read "Free Software Download." This will be displayed in the search results if the Black Hat SEO for this page is successful. However, when the user clicks on the link, it takes them to a page where they are served more ads to click on—and with absolutely nothing to download. Search engines are aware of such techniques and compensate for them. They have become increasingly efficient—though not perfect—at detecting Black Hat SEO. As time progresses, the cost of Black Hat SEO is going to far outweigh the cost of following legitimate practices in making your Web site search-engine-friendly.

White Hat SEO, on the other hand, employs—or at least tries to use—only non-deceptive techniques. The qualification "tries to" stems from the fact that there is a certain amount of grey area in what Webmasters and SEO consultants consider legitimate optimisation and what the search engines agree on. Early on this year, there was a spate of sites that sprang up offering paid reviews from bloggers. This seemed a good idea, especially for little-known sites who wanted to piggyback on the popularity of an established blogger. That's until Google declared paid reviews (and their links) might get penalised or

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removed from search listings.

Black Hat works on the assumption that they will eventually be caught by the search engines and are ready to move on. There is a law of diminishing returns in operation, as search engines get increasingly efficient in proactively detecting Black Hat sites. Eventually, we expect to see the practice minimised to only those die-hard tech criminals with enough resources (time, money, and determination) to use Black Hat as a part of a larger scam operation.

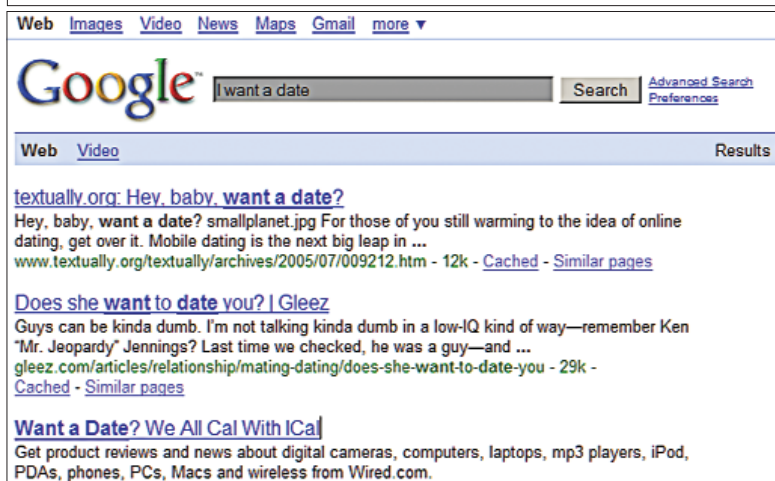
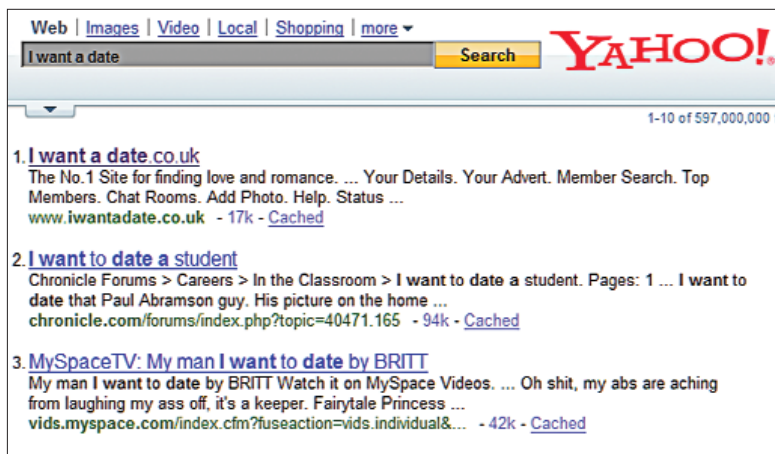
White Hat works with the sole objective of creating a sustainable ranking in the search engine results. Again, this is not bullet-proof: search engines are constantly refining their algorithms to keep up with the latest developments that impact what users want to search for. These days, search engines not only monitor the search results page, but also monitor user behaviour for a given search term. That is, if site A was ranked number 1 on the SERP but users regularly clicked on site B, the number 2 link, then site B would move to the number 1 position. Add to this the fact that search is getting more and more personalised. Google, according to what can be inferred from patent filings, will customise the SERPs based on geographic location, similarity of search patterns with other users, membership on certain Web sites or forums that are discoverable by the Googlebot (the search engine spider software that crawls and indexes Web pages), and other factors that would, in aggregate, group you with a specific set of users who have similar interests.

For example, if you start using Google Finance, Google will start serving financial information in the SERPs. If you are, say, a regular participant at Digit's forum (<http://www.thinkdigit.com/forum/>) and you run a search, Google will look at similar searches from other users in the Digit forum and try to guess what will interest you. Of course, this is a simplified example. Your actual profile will be much more complex, and grouping you with users with similar tastes will involve much more. This is, of course, very good for the user: relevance improves.

But this kind of complexity is a nightmare for SEO practitioners. You can be forgiven for thinking that even White Hat SEO is more voodoo than an art or a science. Fortunately, there are some published guidelines, and over the years, the SEO industry has matured enough to be aware of some basic best practices that can help you in achieving the rankings that you feel you deserve.

## SEO Basics

Determining a specific SEO strategy for your Web site will depend on a number of factors that are beyond our scope here. These include things like at what stage your Web site is—whether it's a start-up or an established site, what your industry is, your target audience, as well as what type of content you have on your site. If you are an e-commerce site, you might need to follow certain optimisation techniques like exposing your product catalogue and making it easy for the search spiders to index the product pages. Here, we look at the basics that will give you a general idea of what you need to do stay on the good side of the search engines. Even if you are not interested in SEO, you



Google does not bring up IWantADate.co.uk for "I want a date" (which is what you might enter if you do!)—though that is the *most obvious* first result. Yahoo! brings it up right on top, so Google probably implements "aging delay" with more strictness